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Scalar Anglosphere: Wasteocene Waters and Vulnerable Bodies in Chioma Okereke's *Water Baby*

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ABSTRACT

The article addresses entangled scales and environmental enmeshment in the 21st-century Anglosphere, with a focus on the novel *Water Baby* (2014) by contemporary Nigerian writer Chioma Okereke, read through the methodological lens of new materialism (Neimanis, Armiero, DeLoughrey) and decolonial critique (Mbembe, Nixon, Newell). The analysis situates Makoko – a floating, unmapped and neglected settlement on the Lagos lagoon – as a site where the asymmetries of the contemporary Anglosphere and its crises become starkly visible. Scales and enmeshment are approached through representations of water and the poetics of water (Mentz, Oppermann), as both a constitutive of the human body and the bodies of nonhuman others, as well as the environment that is both agential and precarious. This methodology allows to examine the interplay of scales in the postcolony, manifesting itself in the temporalities of place, multiscalar inequalities and neocolonial infrastructures producing "wasted" lives and places, exposures and vulnerabilities. Through its immersive portrayal of watery materiality, *Water Baby* reveals how vulnerability is produced across temporal and spatial scales. Drawing on the example of this recent African novel, I show how foregrounding "wasted" bodies and places alongside forms of communal resilience, rendered through blue poetics and narrative hybridization, expand the representational horizons of contemporary Anglophone fiction.

Introduction: Scaling the Anglosphere

Thinking of the events and processes in the contemporary Anglosphere reveals a landscape defined not only by shared language but, importantly, by entangled scales. This helps us see crisis not only as a critical point but as a process or condition emerging from the intersection of ontological scales. What appears as a discrete "event," such as a climate disaster or a political rupture, is already woven into a long *durée* of past imperial relations that shape how communities live, survive, and remember today. The key effect of this entanglement is vulnerability, visible and invisible, as a defining aspect of our times, a condition whose effects are asymmetrically distributed, making it impossible to treat the Anglosphere as a single temporal or social formation. We may see this in the unjust distribution of waste, colonial residue, contemporary technological dependencies, neocolonial extractivism and structural inequalities that make crisis a permanent condition in some locations more intensely than in others, where it also appears very visceral and material. Attention to differentiations within the Anglosphere with regard to crisis echoes the current discussions about the Anthropocene: defined as "the era of the humans" to show the extent to which human activity has affected the planet, it is

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misleading to use it as referring to humanity as a whole. As Timothy Clark stresses, the Anthropocene represents "the dark underbelly of 'modernity'" with all its injustices, colonialism and neocolonialism, as well as "modes of hierarchy and discrimination," which become particularly apparent in a world swept by climate chaos (Clark 24). It is important to see, as this article will try to show, that neither modernity nor Anthropocene or Anglosphere are homogeneous notions and if they are to be grasped at all, then only with regard to scale. Moreover, discussions of both social and environmental crises foreground the reality of the physical body and the environment in which it is enmeshed, as part of a community but also as part of material interdependencies. This deepens the already multiscalar condition of contemporary polycrisis.

This article addresses entangled scales and environmental enmeshment in the 21st-century Anglosphere, with a focus on Chioma Okereke's *Water Baby* as a case-study. Longlisted for the Climate Fiction Prize in 2024, the novel will be read through the methodological lens of new materialism (Neimanis, Armiero, DeLoughrey) and decolonial critique (Mbembe, Nixon, Newell). Scales and enmeshment will be read through representations of water and the poetics of water (Mentz, Oppermann), as both a constitutive of the human body and the bodies of nonhuman[1] others as well as the environment that is both agential and precarious. Using this methodology, I examine the interplay of scales in the postcolony, manifesting itself in temporalities of place, multiscalar inequalities and neocolonial infrastructures producing "wasted" lives and places, exposures and vulnerabilities. How does contemporary Anglophone literature portray these asymmetries, using Nigerian literature as an example? What new methods and techniques, narrative and formal choices are deployed to represent a complex reality, which is both social and material? Are there narrative ways to enable resilience and thus, hope?

The novel is set in Makoko, a floating slum on the Lagos lagoon in Nigeria. The depiction is based on real facts: in this self-organized settlement, which started as a fishing village in the 19th century, houses are built on stilts, there are canals instead of streets and boat traffic. Modern infrastructure is absent and the inhabitants are not liable for social security, medical care, waste management plan, or education. The settlement is not officially recognized by the government, which accounts for its absence on the official maps until recently. The events are narrated by Baby, a 19-year-old Makoko water taxi driver. Against the will of her father, who wants a traditional way of life for her, which would include an early marriage, she participates in a drone-mapping project to put Makoko on the map and is accidentally captured on camera by a visiting foreign press crew. When her photo goes viral on international social media, she has a chance to visit the climate conference in Davos, where the middle part of the story is set. Realizing what is real, what is fake and where she actually belongs, she returns to the community and its water, which closes the novel, but this is not really closure, because water does not end.

"Scalar literacy" or "scale critique" employed in analyzing *Water Baby* are important ecocritical concepts, developed to understand the intersection of local and global processes in relation to memory, migration and ecology. While early ecocriticism was concerned with the cult of locality, predominantly in the western metropole ("romantic localism"), Ursula Heise's *Sense of Place and Sense of Planet* (2008) made clear "the degree in which the local and the global have always been implicated in one another" (Clark, 41). This turns attention to localities and ecologies outside the Euro-American center. However, there is never a locality separate from the complex historical, geopolitical, economic and environmental entanglements, hence the intersection of ecocriticism and decolonialism. As Timothy Clark stresses, one and the same place is likely to be "teetering between post-colonial exploitation and first-world power" (41–42). Proposed by Derek Woods (2014), *scale* is an important critical category, which draws attention to the complexity of today's crises, particularly those concerning the environment and various actors caught in various localities on the entangled planet. In addition to the historical, political and ethical implications of scalar criticism, there is also the nonhuman scale, which calls for a reconsideration of space, but also time while discussing crises such as the environmental one. While humans imagine the state, politics or ecology of a place at a point in time according to human timescale, scale critique shows how local ecosystems evolve over

long periods of time, incompatibly with human perception, often as a result of human-generated processes (e.g., movement of plants and species across continents, damming rivers, reclaiming wetlands or mining). On the other hand, the effects of these planet-altering activities last much longer than the human grasp, for example radiation or plastic pollution, which takes countless human lifetimes to disintegrate. Hence, the state of politics or ecology in a place is always already multiscalar. Seeing its problems "now" is, in Clark's words, but a "freeze-frame" (2019, 39) of all the multidirectional, entangled processes coming before and after (Kuznetski et al., 2024, 3). The purpose of scalar criticism, then, is to illuminate the complexities beyond the freeze-frame of the human vision in space, time, and perception.

Woods proposes to think "assemblage" – "large-scale, horizontal patterns of relation among ontologically different entities" (139). In these relations, various life forms, including humans, as well as technical systems, politics, data, chemical and microscopic worlds, contribute to "terraforming," or the shaping of the earth in what we know as the Anthropocene. Similarly, Elizabeth DeLoughrey underscores that in a scalar approach, "culture, climate, experience, knowledge, and the Anthropocene are all placed in disjunctive relation" (4), in which "the enormity of the planet and the profound experience of local place" (5) always intersect. Engagement with postcolonial and indigenous perspectives is instrumental for thinking on the planetary scale, though sadly lacking in Anthropocene discussions until quite recently. DeLoughrey insists that what we may see as a novelty from a Eurocentric point of view, is in fact part of the "historical *continuity* of dispossession and disaster caused by empire" (DeLoughrey 2, original emphasis). She gestures to Walter Benjamin, who showed that epochs always form *constellations* with one another, which becomes especially evident in moments of historical rupture at the spikes of acute crisis, when previous periods bleed into one another (Benjamin 255). Reminiscing that the momentary flashes in a constellation reveal "history in its totality," DeLoughrey suggests that Benjamin laid the foundation for considering the Anthropocene as a condition of ruins operating on "a disjuncture between humans (history) and the planet (nature)" (6). Therefore, questions of scale always entail questions of ethics and historical as well as environmental situatedness. As Sidney Dobrin writes, "given the scale of representation within textual ecologies the question 'what can we do?' can only be answered ecocritically by examining 'what have we done?' – in both senses of the question" (13). In *Water Baby*, the experience of one very particular place is put into the perspective of the history of the Lagos lagoon and the whole of Nigeria and its neighboring region, which may be considered as an intersection of multiple scales, including the remote and unreal Europe, techno-space, digital space, social media space and the space of a living body and its watery environment, which are given ample attention in the narrative.

Scale, Materiality, Reality

The Lagos lagoon and the slums of Makoko depicted in the book are a concentrate of memory, colonialism, and slow violence. Africa's most populous country and one of the world's largest English-speaking nations, Nigeria has been independent since 1960, and soon after independence a civil war broke out, as the borders drawn by Europeans did not match the actual boundaries of ethnic groups, and natural resources, including oil fields, were not evenly distributed. Even before independence, Nigeria was a "state" stitched together by colonizers, created in 1914 by merging several colonies by the British colonial administrator Cyril Lugard in what he called *amalgamation*. Behind Lugard's efforts were the interests of the empire – notably the objective to develop a railway network to move colonial goods and raw materials from the inland and the North to the port of Lagos in the South, and on to Europe (Oluwatobi). The consequences, such as political fragmentation, regional inequality, and conflicts over natural resources, are felt to this day. Even the name of the country reflects a colonial perspective: it was invented by Lugard's wife, after the River Niger. The name of Lagos derives from the Portuguese word for lagoon- *lagoa*. In comparison with the names of European countries, which are connected with the peoples living there, these are landscape-based names that reflect the European viewpoint: Africa is portrayed as a kind of "empty landscape," a wasteland to be mapped and

"developed." When we think of the Lagos lagoon today, it is a typical landscape of contrasts and contradictions that embodies the legacy of colonialism. On the one hand, it features an urban coastline with luxurious new developments resulting from rapid gentrification of Africa's largest city. Behind this lies the environmentally harmful sand mining and the draining of wetlands with the use of the sand dredged from the seabed, which damages both the seabed and the land being "developed." The situation is intensified by the massive pollution from municipal and industrial waste. All these problems are addressed in Okereke's *Water Baby*, a narrative that allows to move from the Anthropocene in general, as "a planetary totality" (LeLoughry 43), and from the abstract Anglosphere to the very specific locality within a former British colony, to look at the events as the intersection of scales.

According to scale critique, the nature of a phenomenon depends on the scale at which it is considered. Baby recounts the poetic nickname of her native Makoko, "the Venice of Africa," to reference its watery existence and also embellish its reality, which is far from poetic. While this place is juxtaposed to the "real Venice," which Baby has a chance to see while on a European image trip, it is more real to her, and it is Venice that is the "Makoko of Europe" (Okereke 344). This shows how place reputations and even maps are in fact provisional and depend on people's actual, affective attachments to them. Further on, Baby contemplates on the meaning of this place for various interest groups:

> To strangers, it's a slum, a metallic and wooden eyesore built over a stinking bed of ever-mounting sewage, spreading out across the smoke-filled horizon. For the government, it's the impediment between ever larger coffers for them and prime waterfront real estate. But to us, who are from here, Makoko is simply *home*. (3–4)

The community that calls it home is marked by poverty and instability, while for the government it is a place of void, absent, unmapped, having no right to exist. We can recognize the paradigm of inherited violence addressed by major African thinker Achille Mbembe, who showed that the legacy of colonialism does not end with independence, because postcolonial states often repeat the governing structures implanted by colonizers. Suggesting that "not only the state forms but also the colonial rationality [. . .] were quickly reappropriated by Africans," he stresses that the "reappropriation was not merely institutional; it also occurred in material spheres and in the sphere of the *imaginary*" (Mbembe 40, emphasis added).

Makoko's inhabitants are descendants of Africans, mostly Egun and Yoruba migrants from the Niger Delta, Benin, Togo, and Ghana (Okereke 15), who were dispossessed of their land by the British during the colonial era, "born out of necessity two centuries ago when land was in short supply and so people spread out over the water" (23). Now, they are portrayed as victims of the greed of their own government, which reproduces the colonial patterns or gives in to neocolonialism by supporting gentrification in the interest of big tech or luxurious waterfront real estate, owned mostly by "bankers and people with oil" (34), as Baby remarks. Here, we can recognize what Rob Nixon referred to as "socioenvironmental fallout from developmental agendas whose primary beneficiaries live elsewhere" (18) as one of the effects of slow violence, which I will return to later.

This same place is also coveted by tourists, but for a different reason: they engage in voyeurism and poverty porn, exploiting it for entertainment, similarly to safari.

> They [tourists] venture here, wrinkling their noses like they are smelling shit as they're ferried across the lagoon, then choke on diesel fumes and the smell of fish in the air like invisible cloth on the body, though we who live here are long accustomed to it. They come to observe us as if we're animals in a zoo or in the wild, and are almost taken aback when they realise we're just people. Hardworking people; living and loving like the rest of the planet. (33)

Here, the difference between the outside gaze and the actual experience of living in a place is foregrounded. The multiscalarity and contradictory life in Makoko are described through vivid material imagery, which combines the effects of the natural local environment and the toxic pollution it is subjected to. The narrative texture is highly olfactory and immersive, permeating the whole novel, especially the Makoko-set part, allowing us to intensely perceive the life that the protagonist is living, by feeling and smelling it.

However, next to the immersive realism of the description is the narrator's awareness of a voyeuristic tourist gaze, in which we can recognize another characteristic of neocolonial thinking: the lasting trope of the animal applied to viewing and describing the African experience. Mbembe referred to it as "a meta-text about the *animal* [. . .] about the *beast*: its experience, its world, and its *spectacle*." (1, original emphasis, added for "spectacle"). In his view, this "meta-text" operates on the tension of the strange and the monstrous found both in the animal and the colonial Other, and of irrevocable intimacy – the recognition of humanity in a living body "just like mine," yet the refusal to recognize that humanity or a form of life as identifiable with the self (1–2). Mbembe attributes this to the whole philosophical and political tradition in the West that has seen "*the problem of the 'I' of others and of human beings we perceive as foreign to us*" as an insurmountable difficulty (2, original emphasis). This tradition results in continually seeing Africa as a void, assigning it "to a special unreality [. . .] whose special feature is to be nothing at all." (4). Even in the more progressive view of the African, which Mbembe calls Bergsonian, the "animal" could be accepted as potentially familiar and lovable, but only after a process of domestication and "grooming," whereof "the colonizer might inculcate habits in the colonized" (27), while being conscious that it still "could never truly accede to the *sphere of human possibility*" (28, original emphasis). In *Water Baby*, the lasting paradigm of the void shrinks to a certain locality, the blank space on the map where Makoko should be, and the precariousness of its population (currently estimated to be around 300,000, Ottaviani). Subject to constant threat of elimination and eviction, the inhabitants appear as unlivable and ungrievable lives.[2] The drone-mapping initiative is an attempt at presenting the lives of the community as livable and making their reality real. It is also another way of negotiating scale and relativity of experience for the protagonist, who perceives the familiar place from a different perspective when flying the drone the first time: "from the sky, the wooden house posts jutting out of the water, the proud columns and squares of aluminum and wood, the boats gliding by like endless smiles, Makoko is a thing of beauty" (110). The scaling effect, which combined digital technology and community spirit (the drone project being a purely grassroots initiative), is what contributed to the reality of the place as an assemblage. Despite the official efforts to invisibilize them, Baby is overjoyed to observe: "It truly *is* a map I'm seeing of our world. We're real. Now we're existing in a way nobody can deny" (109). However, zooming out the scale further by going to a climate conference in Davos makes her conscious of the gaze and far-reaching neo-imperial structures. First, she realizes that those who arranged her participation in the climate conference are not interested in her reality as a person, but just want her to be the face of a cause, similar to Malala or Greta Thunberg. Second, she cannot help the feeling "of slowly becoming a performing monkey" (344). Mbembe writes about such distancing performativity in the past tense, comparing the colonial subject to an animal as "an object of experimentation in a game that the colonizer played with himself/herself, conscious that between him/her and the colonized there hardly existed a community of essence" (27). In a similar manner, Baby senses that her presence in a 2020s Davos is not to be taken seriously, but to provide a flavor of entertainment for the self-appointed "real people," who are there "to fix the big issues of the world" (345) and thus deserve a bit of voyeuristic pleasure. As she concludes, "[t]here's a thin line between them being curious about our circumstances and us becoming curiosities (345).

The narrative counter-strategy employed in the novel is the reversal of the gaze in scaling both Europe and Africa. The viscous materiality of the Lagos lagoon is juxtaposed to the unreality of such distant places as Switzerland, which is in the heart of Europe, but provincialized in a narrative foregrounding the African imagination.[3] For Baby, the blue of Lake Davos is artificial and unnatural to the effect that she compares it to "the liquid hue of a mouthwash" (290), while the brown of the polluted lagoon at home is natural in her perception. Another inversion is that the narrator recalls the European poetic designation for Paris as City of Lights and acknowledges that it is in fact "Lagos that better bears that name" (350). It is interesting to note how the colonial clichés are subverted in these descriptions: City of Lights vs. Dark Continent; sterile cleanliness vs. implied dirt. The novel brings in the imagery of dirt as a distinct characteristic of the materiality of Makoko. However, there is more to dirt than pollution or lack of hygiene.

In *Histories of Dirt* (2019), Stephanie Newell explores dirt as an interpretive category in the West, developed during the colonial period and still lingering in stereotypical discourses in the present. She shows how it enables the judging of other cultures not only on sanitary, but also economic, moral and aesthetic grounds by placing them within a framework of dirtiness. Newell cites British merchants' 1853 descriptions of Lagos as "a dirty, nasty, savage place, where walking the streets is dangerous" (2). In this account, dirt and danger are indispensably connected, starting a paradigm in which even foreign appearance, customs, and food figure as repulsive, something to be eliminated through "improvement." Such "improvement" took place during the colonial period, with the British "clean-up" projects, aiming to eradicate malaria by reclaiming wetlands and mangrove forests, which used to predominantly constitute the landscape of the lagoon, and then to develop the drained land for their own settlements. Wetlands are balanced ecosystems, highly important for the climate, while mangrove trees function as natural sponges absorbing pollutants. However, in western discourse, wetlands are often framed as wild, "marshy and disturbing" dirty areas that must be ordered and tamed, especially when located in colonies (Anderson and Chain). Wetland reclamation brought strain on the ecosystem and loss of home as well as traditional livelihoods, such as fishing. Moreover, the narrative frames of "disorder, inefficiency, borderline humanity" as extreme forms of social othering (Newell 117) are still deployed in portraying the place in a condescending and judgmental manner, even in recent documentaries, such as the BBC's *Welcome to Lagos* (2010), which Newell analyses as a telling case (115–123). She mentions further present-day journalistic accounts, which include Makoko and other coastal settlements, described as "the most uninhabitable places in the world. Yet, *human beings* are living there" (140, emphasis added). This imagined dissonance between harsh material circumstances and the possibility of humanity is mirrored in *Water Baby* in the description of tourists and journalists canoed through permasmog (107) of the "floating junkyard" (57), "the burn of sulfur and shit high in [one's]nostrils," with their eyes "agape in wonder as though they are on a safari" (88). A way of countering this distancing gaze is zooming in on life on the lagoon, through an immersive materiality, especially the material transcorporeality of water, which is the focus of the next section.

Water and Its Ambiguities

Water in the novel represents both life and danger, which matches the dual nature of Makoko. Water is a key element in the storyline, a constituent of the human body, the source of life on the lagoon, but also the source of death. Baby contemplates on the paradox in recounting the story of her birth in a canoe, when her mother nearly lost her: "There's a high rate of maternal and infant death among those living on the water, which is strange considering that we all come from the womb having been surrounded by liquid" (4). Here, we can see how people, though being bodies of water in terms of hydrocommons,[4] are susceptible to danger from that very element, because of the environmental risks it is exposed to. A transcorporeal perspective is essential here, theorized by Stacy Alaimo as a reciprocal interdependence of a porous, vulnerable body with bodies of others, human and nonhuman, with matters, elements and textures involved in body's becoming (2010). Building on Alaimo's concept, Astrida Neimanis (2017) proposes a phenomenology of water that troubles the assumption of water being something "out there," as "environment, resource, commodity, backdrop," insisting that it is *right here*, as "the stuff of human bodies, and never separate from our own incontestable materiality" (21). For Neimanis, the "worlded" water crisis arises from the "entanglement of material water scarcity and pollution with our *idea* of water" (20, original emphasis). Indeed, this inherited idea frames water as a distant, utilitarian substance. As geographer Jamie Linton pointed out, the concept of "modern water" as an abstraction expressed by H_2O is a legacy of the European Enlightenment and its rationalist paradigm, which subsequently enabled the institutional management and commodification of water (Linton 14) rather than recognizing it as the very matter we consist of and a medium of shared vulnerability. This way, it can be argued that we are *trained* into perceiving water as separate from us, even though our bodies, being porous and vulnerable, consisting of water by about seventy per cent, are always already entangled in watery exchanges with others, comprising an "an elemental-

environmental hydrocommons" (Neimanis 80). This calls for alternative narratives, which have the potential to *un*train us into alternative stories, which invite thinking *with* water in order to overcome what Serpil Oppermann (2023) calls the *biocultural* setting of boundaries. Seen through the narrator's experience, these theoretical currents take material form in the novel, as the watery origins and the precarious intimacy with the lagoon are felt in the community's transcorporeal entanglement and textures of everyday life. Such narrative technique has been termed *blue poetics* by Steve Mentz (2024), who coined the term, as "connect[ing] water with human ideas," where pleasure "arises from the sense of proximity to pain" (2–3), as the original Aristotelian term implies. The contemporary *blue* poetics, however, favors hybrid modes of representation, allowing to better grasp the complex, crisis-ridden reality of water bodies. As Baby witnesses a group of young boys diving for their kites in polluted waters, she describes the scene as a combination of beauty and peril, as is characteristic of this book:

> Beads of water fly from his skin like black diamonds. Try as you might, there's no keeping people completely out of this filthy water filled with plastic and metal scraps. Where human shit and hazardous chemicals combat for dominance. You can't stop them from entering the lagoon that has mercilessly taken children one way or another. (105)

This is a further instance of the dual nature of the lagoon, its precarity and agency. Residential and industrial waste contaminating the waters comprises the stark realist layer of the description. At the same time, the lagoon may be seen as a super-character that gives life and takes it, which matches the contradictory nature of water in general. In *At the Water's Edge* (1998), evolutionary biologist Carl Zimmer recounts our shared ancestry with sea mammals and even fish and speaks of the development of a "fatal boundary" (6) in the course of evolution. Water is our origin, but we cannot survive in this element, having forgotten how to breathe in it. The "fatal boundary" has developed into a conceptual divide: we associate ourselves more with air and dry land, though being water. For the Makoko community, this manifests both in their uniqueness and othering: their intimacy with water creates a strong communal identity, while also resulting in social isolation and political precariousness, and may be seen as a manifestation of *slow violence*. Theorized by Rob Nixon, slow violence is "neither spectacular nor instantaneous, but rather incremental and accretive, its calamitous repercussions playing out across a range of temporal scales" (2). This applies to pollution and the effects of climate change, which less privileged human groups experience most acutely, disproportionately to environmental culpability. These invisible, slow-burning forms of social injustice, such as exposure to toxic pollution, have a disastrous effect on socially insecure populations, and are in effect no less destructive than "fast" forms of violence, such as wars.

The community relies on the lagoon for their livelihood, fishing being its main source, thus one manifestation of slow violence and environmental entanglement is the depletion of fish. "Every year there's more flooding and fewer fish. They're all dying in dirty water, choking on all the rubbish inside the lagoon" (32). This statement communicates multiple effects: the perishing of sea life as the result of a ruined ecosystem, industrial pollution and climate change, and the predicament of people depending on this ecosystem as part of its food chain. These are all, in Nixon's terms, the "delayed effects" of slow violence (Nixon 3). We learn in passing that the men in the community have to work in a sawmill or dredge for sand (13), having no longer the possibility to sustain themselves by fishing alone, due to lack of fish. As mentioned before, sand dredging is an environmentally harmful activity, as is timber processing, which is also dangerous for the people involved, as testified by the accident Baby's father has at the mill where he works out of necessity, after spending most of his life as a fisherman (337). This reveals the tendency of environmental violence being outsourced to the very people dispossessed by it, as its another slow form. This precariousness is expressed by Baby, who has already lost her mother and brother, as another indispensable aspect of living on the lagoon. We see how the transcorporeal and the fatalistic intermingle in her musings about her father's injury:

> Loss was something all inhabitants of Makoko experienced; it surrounded us like the lagoon. No one would dare drink the black water directly, knowing how badly it would harm the body, but it always found its way into us just the same. (338)

Here, "black water" refers directly to pollution, and simultaneously to bad luck, which again has both spiritual and social dimension, and is further associated with the dual nature of the water that permeates the narrative. Another instance of this is the interplay of birth and death, reinforced by the presence of child characters. Baby's birth in the canoe, almost fatal to her mother, contains strong water-creaturely imagery, describing the newborn as slimy and resembling a scared fish "struggling to take in the air out of the water" and being "as beautiful as a mermaid" (5). Interestingly, in the same scene, the father who receives the baby, is himself "covered in sweat and scales" (5), from his day's work as a fisherman, to stress the family's embeddedness in the lagoon and its more-than-human life. Years later, Baby will be helping her friend Idunnu on the same lagoon, performing an illegal abortion in her boat. Everything is liminal about the scene, as blood runs out of Idunnu together with the unborn (167), and she herself "floats in and out of consciousness" on the rippling waves (168), witnessed only by fish, the inky night (166), and Baby's ghost brother, dead for seven years but appearing at critical moments. Mystery and the material flow of life and death fluids intermingle. However, we also recognize the social dimension, namely lack of sexual education, unavailability of birth control and proper medical care, and a strong social prejudice that pushes the teenager to the dangerous choice as another form of slow violence.

We can say that the lagoon is a space of the *Wasteocene* and the characters are its inhabitants. Building on Nixon's ideas, Marco Armiero (2021) proposes this term as a more accurate rendition of our epoch than Anthropocene, due to its attention to the social dimension of waste. Armiero warns that "the 'we' of the Anthropocene risks depicting humans as an undifferentiated community" (6), which does not include everyone, or everyone equally. Even if we are all in the Anthropocene, "we are not in it in the same way" (6), he goes on saying, as some are still more privileged, while others are themselves seen as waste to be discarded. This concept is inseparably connected to the physical body, which Armiero sees as a porous space (following Alaimo), operating on the boundary of "privilege and disposability, purity and contamination, life and death" (12). Idunnu and her unborn baby are a telling example of disposable bodies in a wasted environment. That abortion takes place in the thick of night and is medically unrecorded, just like the place itself is not recorded on the maps, is a manifestation of invisibilization, which is another feature of the Wasteocene: "erasing what does not fit in the mainstream narrative" as a "common dispositif" (Armiero 19). It is a typical combination of "dilapidated landscape around the protagonists," which "enters their bodies, radically changing the very nature of their being humans" (14). Idunnu eventually severs all links with the place by choosing to disappear from the enironmental congress in Davos. She does not leave a trace, erased from the conversation and memory of the organizers, who do not want to turn the incident into an embarrassment. Baby thinks of her swapping the moist and smelly heat of Makoko for the electric sensation of snow against her skin (358) – another phase of water; and it is only the lapping of the waves against the canoe, rhyming with Idunnu's name, that holds the memory of her. Thus we can see, next to erasure, the agentic narrative power of water in the Wasteocene. Armiero calls this narrative resistance "guerrilla narrative," which takes the form of "embodiment [that] trespasses the border of the storyteller's body and becomes a more choral bodily narrative" (24), including "voices from the underworld," coming from "wasted bodies" engaged in "wasting relationships" (22), otherwise invisibilized. Baby assumes this role, not only as the mapper of the place, determined to continue her drone project, now to be amplified by the digital platforms maintained by her friends, but also as a storyteller, who is both digital and nonhuman: "I was a fish a fish out of water that had endured a long stretch on dry land and had lived to tell the tale" (349).

Trauma, Memory and Spirituality

The convergence of fast and slow violence manifests in the deep trauma that Baby's family experienced. The novel recounts the historical events of 2012, when the government gave the residents of Makoko a seventy-two-hour eviction order and thereafter destroyed a large part of the settlement with machetes and chainsaws. According to some sources, it was the aforementioned BBC documentary

Welcome to Lagos that infuriated Lagos officials and led to the decision to eliminate the settlement altogether, for the sake of the city's overall reputation (Lagos Makoko). Others point to exclusionary policies, where the voices of local residents are drowned out by elite politicians, as "embedded in the history of the place," ever since the early postcolonial era (1950s) and continuing into the projects such as Eko Atlantic, a luxurious beachfront, built on land reclaimed from the ocean (Somotan). In the book, Baby carries the inter-generational traumatic memory of a similar demolition, two decades earlier, which "uprooted many families" (119), turning them into what Nixon calls developmental refugees, forming "a terrifying, centrifugal narrative of displacement, dispossession, and exodus" of communities which he describes as "in the most literal sense, inundated by development" (Nixon 152). In Baby's words, the luxury district was "created from space stolen from the community that had resided on the fringes of Bar Beach long before the billionaires moved in and commandeered the waterfront" (Okereke 119). This trauma amplifies her own experience of losing home, which also meant losing the memory of her mother, who had lived and died in that house: "the buzz of the saw cut through my thoughts and made her disappear" (119). The superimposition of memories and the history of place revisits Benjaminian constellations and spikes as moments of crisis, which, according to DeLoughrey, represents decline as an allegory of ruins, a universal condition of the Anthropocene (DeLoughrey 6). Drawing together earlier theoretical strands, the concept of Wasteocene is again helpful in this scalar discourse: if the future is in ruins, then again, these ruins do not come in a universal shape for all. Baby replays the events in her memory as the struggle of force, technology and power, destruction coming from the hands of men who she calls monsters and who "wielded electrical tools like true *power*" (117, emphasis added), "delighted in their handiwork, [. . .] the fury of their weapons (117). She observes the bizarre demolition site metabolism, as bamboo and driftwood are plunged "back into the lagoon from whence it came" (117) as another manifestation of the transcorporeal connection of the community, their material existence and the water they are part of, in life and death. The family find shelter at a relatives' home, already crammed with refugees, and this is when the real tragedy strikes. In the chaos of the unknown place, the disappearance of the familiar way of life, the protagonist's five-year old brother Charlie tries to enter the host family's boat, slips and drowns. The heart-breaking description renders him as a wasted life in a wasted place:

> Later that day we discovered him [. . .] his beautiful broken form in his Spider-Man T-shirt, his tattered blue short knicker blending into the rotting pile of rubbish accumulating between the stilts underneath the house. [. . .] they pulled his flaccid body from the water, from the scum accumulating around the house's wooden posts [. . .] The one eye that had remained partially open [. . .] had been the colour of the lagoon. (121)

We can guess that the color was that of viscous coffee, in an eerie transcorporeal blend with the deadly lagoon, which used to be life-giving. We can also see the blend of global mass culture and fast fashion (Charlie's T-shirt) and local waste, which now includes a child as a disposable body, a life among many others. The sensory details make the description especially visceral. "Scum" refers here to the actual filth, impurities floating on the surface of water. At the same time, it refers to decay and disregard, of both the place being structurally degraded, and the human child caught in the materiality of that abandonment. His death is thus framed by an environment that is itself sick, fouled, and neglected.

However, this book manages to turn tragedy into magic: Charlie-Boy keeps coming back to his sister as a ghost and is as real to her as being alive. In fact, he is present throughout the narrative, but it is not before page 116 that we realize that Baby is actually talking to a ghost, holding hands, sharing meals and secrets with him. This way, Charlie is a disposable body for the larger structures of Wasteocene, but he is unique and alive for Baby. He is also a part of an interrupted chain, witnessing manifestations of violence and its lasting effects. On the narrative level, this can be viewed as a countermeasure to the western individualist neoliberal practice, first described by John Berger and referenced by Nixon, of "rendering the deceased immaterial" (Nixon 18), thus breaking the temporal, symbolic and material connections of pre-industrial societies, which viewed the living and the dead as interdependent. Every place, Nixon stresses, is not only spatial but also temporal, and "constantly renegotiated in the face of changes coming from within and without" (18), which also fits the discourse

of crisis, which can be only understood as an overlapping of scales discussed above. In the case of Makoko, we can see this "temporality of place" in the intertwining of communal, ancestral memory and the body of water in which these memories are embedded. As the quotation from Toni Morrison used as an epigraph states, "water has a perfect memory and is trying to get back to where it was" (1). Thus, Baby's communication with the long-dead Charlie is not just a fantasy or a manifestation of deep-seated trauma, but a way to suggest these interdependences. Her brother and mother are a part of the watery flow that fills her own body and cannot separate them. Baby's recurring memory and her life-straw in moments of crisis is her mother's teaching that "women *are* water. Quiet and calming or powerful and flowing" and in order to have her way in life, to be able to "break any rock," she has to "be like water" (22, emphasis added).

Perhaps the most beautiful place in the book is the protagonist's reverie in which she talks to a figure signifying both her lost mother and Yoruba goddess Yemoja, after whom she has been named (Baby being just a nickname). Yemoja is an important hydrogenous goddess, worshipped by the Yoruba people among other traditional deities, which abide mainly in natural phenomena such as mountains, valleys and oceans. These divinities are linked to spaces and spiritualities that formed identities despite the colonial partition of Africa (Ogunleye 60). Her name's origin translated as "mother of fishes," Yemoja is the chief goddess, associated with bodies of water and amniotic fluid, protector of fishermen and those who live on the water or travel by water, including voluntary and involuntary migrants, and those transported as slaves on the Middle Passage, who she followed and protected (Ogunleye 61). Humans are also believed to have been created from the waters of Yemoja's womb. This accounts for the unifying imagery of humans and fish that permeates Okereke's novel, and the enmeshment of the intense physicality and materiality of the present with deities, ancestors and a larger metaphysical order. As Mbembe (2022) contends, human uniqueness is but a western myth; in African cosmology, all forms of life are on one and the same ontological level. "The society of humans was merely a singular segment *of the general community of beings, which included the dead*" (*Earthly Community* 19, original emphasis), forming a "vital chain" of "ancestors [. . .], water, the sun, rocks, plants, fish, animals, birds, spirits [and] the unborn (29). This explains why in the reverie scene, Baby's mother, goddess and water are one, distinctions are blurred. What is more, Baby herself is naturally breathing underwater, just like we were all able to do originally, in the womb or million years ago, in our watery ancestors, before the development of the "fatal boundary" cited above.

> She's not scary as she rises out of the waves. *She is* the wave, the water, I realise as I stare at her, transfixed by how the liquid appears to be her vibrant skirt before my gaze moves up the silver fish scale bodice of her outfit to take in her metallic crown and head-tie combination. Her long braids move like sea serpents, undulating behind her with the current, which is what alerts me to the fact that I'm under the water with her and having no trouble breathing. (341)

Just like with earlier travelers, Yemoja/mother has followed Baby to the far away Switzerland, to remind her of who she is and where she belongs. This is again rendered transcorporeally, as the protagonist starts feeling "bits of refuse" filling her mouth and the clear aquamarine waves are turning brown (342), by way of the native lagoon calling her back. Her waking "drenched in sweat" embodies the intertwining of reality and dream, through water that never leaves our bodies, being our primeval constitution. The return to Makoko fills her with "the unmistakable odour of fish and waste, the black waves: they *were* my blood" (355, original emphasis). This feeling of home is an embodied experience, where her senses, memories, and corporeal being are interwoven with the environment and its radical materiality. Water and waves as being her blood are both transcorporeal and mythological with no separation between these in the novel. Once again, we recognize blue poetics, which involves "methodologies that are hybrid, transdisciplinary, generative, fluid, uncertain and transformative" (Oppermann 6), with non-linear stories, fluid characters, nonhuman time-scale and enmeshed relationships, pointing to reciprocal influence and vulnerability of watery bodies, human and nonhuman. Through the analysis of *Water Baby*, we may add a focus on the erosion of boundaries, mythology and magic becoming reality, de-hierarchizing and provincializing the western tradition,

while focussing on a watery locality and indigenous cosmology, enmeshed in global material and symbolic connections. Significantly, the hierarchical symbolism of the "blue" itself is challenged in the novel, by presenting a whole spectrum of the lagoon water: it is most often brown, but also comes as black, charcoal, and even orange. This physicality, attention to the temporality of place and intersection of scales allows to better understand crisis, which is local but embedded in and resulting from ineluctable globality. As Armiero contends, the contemporary Wasteocene is characterized not only by contaminating substances and environments but, importantly, by contaminating narratives. Attention to overlapping scales, temporalities and forms of social and structural inequality as well as violence calls for a more complex representation, which disturbs habitual western epistemologies. The character's experience as the body of the story-teller is instrumental in facilitating this representation, by creating a narrative that could untrain the reader in their perception of complex processes and crises, thus expanding the horizons of contemporary Anglophone writing as representational of the multiscalar Anglosphere.

Notes

1. I use the spelling nonhuman, without hyphenation, to avoid the connotations of a lack and stress the equal value of human and nonhuman.
2. See Butler 2004.
3. I am referring to DeLoughrey's suggestion that "we must "provincialize" the Anthropocene, much as postcolonial studies "provincialized" the universalizing discourse of Eu□rope (2). In *Water Baby*, it is Europe that is provincialized and the locality of Makoko and its very visceral representation that is made real, existing and mattering.
4. The term refers to the idea that all beings, human and nonhuman bodies and environments are connected through shared, circulating water (Neimanis, *passim*).

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